2BR02B

Pronounced To Be or Naught To Be

By Kurt Vonnegut

NARRATOR: Everything was perfectly swell. There were no prisons, no slums, no insane asylums, no [disabilities], no wars. All diseases were conquered. So was old age. Death, barring accidents, was an adventure for volunteers. The population of the United States was stabilized at forty million souls.

INTRODUCTION

The future Kurt Vonnegut describes sounds amazing, doesn't it. But unfortunately, it hinges on a concept that most people rarely consider: Population control. In 1979 the Chinese government implemented a policy to control its population: 1 child per family. Families meeting this expectation received numerous economic incentives. It worked so well that the birth rate declined rapidly, and the restrictions were relaxed in May of 2021 to allow women to bear up to three children.

Kurt Vonnegut in his story 2BR02B imagines a future for the United States that institutes a different version of population control.

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NARRATOR: One bright morning at the Chicago Lying-In Hospital, a man named Edward K. Wehling, Jr., waited for his wife to give birth. He was the only man waiting. Not many people were born each day anymore. Wehling was fifty-six, a mere stripling in a population whose average age was one hundred twenty-nine. X rays had revealed that his wife was going to have triplets. The children would be his first.

Young Wehling was hunched in his chair, his head in his hand. He was so rumpled, so still and colorless as to be virtually invisible. His camouflage was perfect, since the waiting room had a disorderly and demoralized air, too. Chairs and ashtrays had been moved away from the walls. The floor was paved with spattered drop cloths. The room was being redecorated. It was being redecorated as a memorial to a man who had volunteered to die.

A sardonic old man, about two hundred years old, sat on a stepladder, painting a mural he did not like. Back in the days when people aged visibly, his age would have been guessed at thirty-five or so. Aging had

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touched him that much before the cure for aging was found.

The mural he was working on depicted a very neat garden. Men and women in white, doctors and nurses, turned the soil, planted seedlings, sprayed bugs. Men and women in purple uniforms pulled up weeds, cut down plants that were old and sickly and carried refuse to trash burners.

A hospital orderly came down the corridor . . .

ORDERLY: (*singing under his breath a popular song. He stops to look at the mural)* Looks so real. I can practically imagine I'm standing in the middle of it.

PAINTER: What makes you think you're not in it? *(smiling)* It's called The Happy Garden of Life, you know.

ORDERLY: That's good of Dr. Hitz. . .

NARRATOR: Dr. Benjaminm Hitz, the hospital's Chief Obstetrician.

ORDERLY: Lots of faces still to fill in.

NARRATOR: He meant that the faces of many of the figures in the mural were blank. All blanks were to be filled with the portraits of important people either on

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the hospital staff or from the Chicago office of the Federal Bureau of Termination.

ORDERLY: Must be nice to be able to make pictures that look like something.

PAINTER: *(with a scornful look)* You think I'm proud of this? You think this is my idea of what life really looks like?

ORDERLY: You're a gloomy old duck, aren't you?

PAINTER: Is that a crime?

ORDERLY: If you don't like it here, Grandpa . . . 2BR02B

NARRATOR: 2BR02B -- The trick telephone number that people who didn't want to live anymore were supposed to call. "To Be or Not to Be" was the telephone number of the municipal gas chambers of the Federal Bureau of Termination. [Also called]: The Automat; The Happy Hooligan; and Why Worry?

PAINTER: *(with derision)* When I decide it's time to go, it won't be at the Automat.

ORDERLY: A do-it-yourselfer, eh? Messy business, Grandpa. Why don't you have a little consideration for the people who have to clean up after you?

PAINTER: The world could do with a good deal more mess, if you ask me.

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NARRATOR: A coarse, formidable woman strode into the waiting room on spike heels. Her shoes, stockings, trench coat, bag, and overseas cap were all purple, a purple the painter called "the color of grapes on Judgement Day." The medallion on her purple bag was the seal of the Service Division of the Federal Bureau of Termination, an eagle perched on a turnstile.

The woman had a lot of facial hair--an unmistakable mustache, in fact. A curious thing about gas chamber hostesses was that no matter how lovely and feminine they were when recruited, they all sprouted mustaches within five years or so.

LEORA: They told me I was supposed to pose for some picture. My name's Leora Duncan. *(pause as she admires the painting)* That sure is a beautiful picture. Looks just like heaven or something.

PAINTER: Or something. *(taking a list of names from his pocket)* Duncan, Duncan, Duncan. *(scanning the list)* Yes--here you are. You're entitled to be immortalized. See any faceless body here you'd like me to stick your head on? We've got a few choice ones left. As a

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master of the fine arts I recommend this body here. *(pointing to a figure)*

LEORA: Well, that's more the disposal people, isn't it? I mean, I'm in service. I don't do any disposing.

PAINTER: *(in mock delight)* You say you don't know anything about art, and then you prove in the next breath that you do know more about it than I do! *(pointing to another faceless figure)* How about her?

LEORA: Gosh—(blushing and humble) That--that puts me right next to Dr. Hitz. It's--it's just such an honor. He was responsible for setting up the very first gas chamber in Chicago.

PAINTER: Nothing would please me more than to put you next to him for all time. Sawing off a limb – that strikes you as appropriate?

LEORA: That is kind of like what I do.

NARRATOR: She was demure about what she did. What she did was make people comfortable while she killed them. And while Leora Duncan was posing for her portrait, into the waiting room bounded Dr. Hitz himself. He was seven feet tall, and he boomed with importance, accomplishments, and the joy of living.

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DR. HITZ: Well, Miss Duncan! Miss Duncan! *(joking)* What are you doing here? This isn't where the people leave. This is where they come in!

LEORA: *(Shyly)* We're going to be in the same picture together.

DR. HITZ: I'm honored to be in it with you. Without women like you, this wonderful world we've got wouldn't be possible. *(Salutes and moves off)* Guess what was just born? Triplets!

LEORA: *(aghast)* Triplets!

NARRATOR: She was exclaiming over the legal implications of triplets. The law said that no newborn child could survive unless the parents of the child could find someone who would volunteer to die. Triplets, if they were all to live, called for three volunteers.

LEORA: Do the parents have three volunteers?

DR. HITZ: Last I heard, they had one, and were trying to scrape another two up.

LEORA: I don't think they made it. Nobody made three appointments with us. Nothing but singles going through today, unless somebody called in after I left. What's the name?

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WEHLING: *(perking up, red-eyed and frowzy, he raises his hand)* Wehling -- Edward. K. Wehling, Jr., is the name of the happy father-to-be.

DR. HITZ: Oh, Mr. Wehling, I didn't see you. They just phoned me that your triplets have been born. They're all fine and so is the mother. I'm on my way in to see them now.

WEHLING: *(emptily)* Hooray.

DR. HITZ: You don't sound very happy.

WEHLING: What man in my shoes wouldn't be happy? All I have to do is pick out which one of the triplets is going to live, then deliver my maternal grandfather to the Happy Hooligan, and come back here with a receipt.

DR. HITZ: *(severely)* You don't believe in population control, Mr. Wehling? Would you like to back to the good old days, when the population of the earth was twenty billion--about to become forty billion, then eighty billion, then one hundred and sixty billion? *(pause)* Do you know what a drupelet is, Mr. Wehling? A drupelet, Mr. Wehling, is one of the little knobs, one of the little pulpy grains, of a blackberry. Without population control, human beings would now be

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packed on the surface of this old planet like drupelets on a blackberry! Think of it! In the year 2000, before scientists stepped in and laid down the law, there wasn't even enough drinking water to go around, and nothing to eat but seaweed -- and yet still people insisted on their right to reproduce like jackrabbits. And their right, if possible, to live forever.

WEHLING: I want those kids. I want all three of them. I don't want my grandfather to die, either.

DR. HITZ: *(sympathetically)* Nobody's really happy about taking a close relative to the Automat.

LEORA: I wish people wouldn't call it that. It gives people the wrong impression.

DR. HITZ: You're absolutely right. Forgive me. I should have said `Ethical Suicide Studios. *(to Wehling)* This child of yours--whichever one you decide to keep, Mr. Wehling. He or she is going to live on a happy, roomy, clean, rich planet, thanks to population control. In a garden like that mural there. *(shaking his head)* Two centuries ago, when I was a young man, it was a hell that nobody thought could last another twenty years.

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Now centuries of peace and plenty stretch before us as far as the imagination cares to travel.

WEHLING: *(Drawing a revolver – he shoots Dr. Hitz)* There's room for one--a great big one. *(He shoots Leora)* It's only death. There! Room for two. *(He puts the gun to his own head and fires)*

NARRATOR: And then he shot himself, making room for all three of his children. Nobody came running. Nobody, it seemed, had heard the shots. The painter sat on the top of his stepladder, looking down reflectively on the sorry scene. [He] pondered the mournful puzzle of life demanding to be born and, once born, demanding to be fruitful ... to multiply and to live as long as possible--to do all that on a very small planet that would have to last forever.

All the answers that the painter could think of were grim. He thought of war. He thought of plague. He thought of starvation. He knew that he would never paint again. He let his paint brush fall to the drop cloths below. And then he decided he had had about

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enough of the Happy Garden of Life, too, and he came slowly down from the ladder.

He took Wehling's pistol, really intending to shoot himself. But he didn't have the nerve. And then he saw the telephone booth in the corner of the room. He went to it, dialed the well-remembered number: 2BR02B.

HOSTESS ON THE PHONE: *(warmly)* Federal Bureau of Termination.

PAINTER: How soon could I get an appointment?

HOSTESS: We could probably fit you in late this afternoon, sir. It might be even earlier, if we get a cancellation.

PAINTER: All right. Fit me in, if you please.

NARRATOR: And he gave her his name, spelling it out.

HOSTESS: Thank you, sir. Your city thanks you, your country thanks you, your planet thanks you. But the greatest thanks of all is from future generations.

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